

Dawood University Of Engineering & Technology

Fall of Dhaka – 1971: Causes, Events, and Consequences

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Foundations and Context

Fall of Dhaka – 1971



Presentation Overview

This presentation focuses on the 1971 Fall of Dhaka, covering causes, events, and consequences. The Fall of Dhaka in December 1971 marks a pivotal moment, leading to the creation of Bangladesh. This presentation explores the deep-rooted causes, from political tensions to economic disparities, that escalated into a brutal civil war. We will examine the key milestones, the intervention of India, and the far-reaching consequences that continue to shape the geopolitical landscape of South Asia today.

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Historical Background

Birth of Bangladesh: A Turning Point in South Asian History

Fall of Dhaka

The Fall of Dhaka in December 1971 was the decisive event leading to Bangladesh's independence.

Underlying Causes

Political tensions and economic disparities escalated into a brutal civil war in East Pakistan.

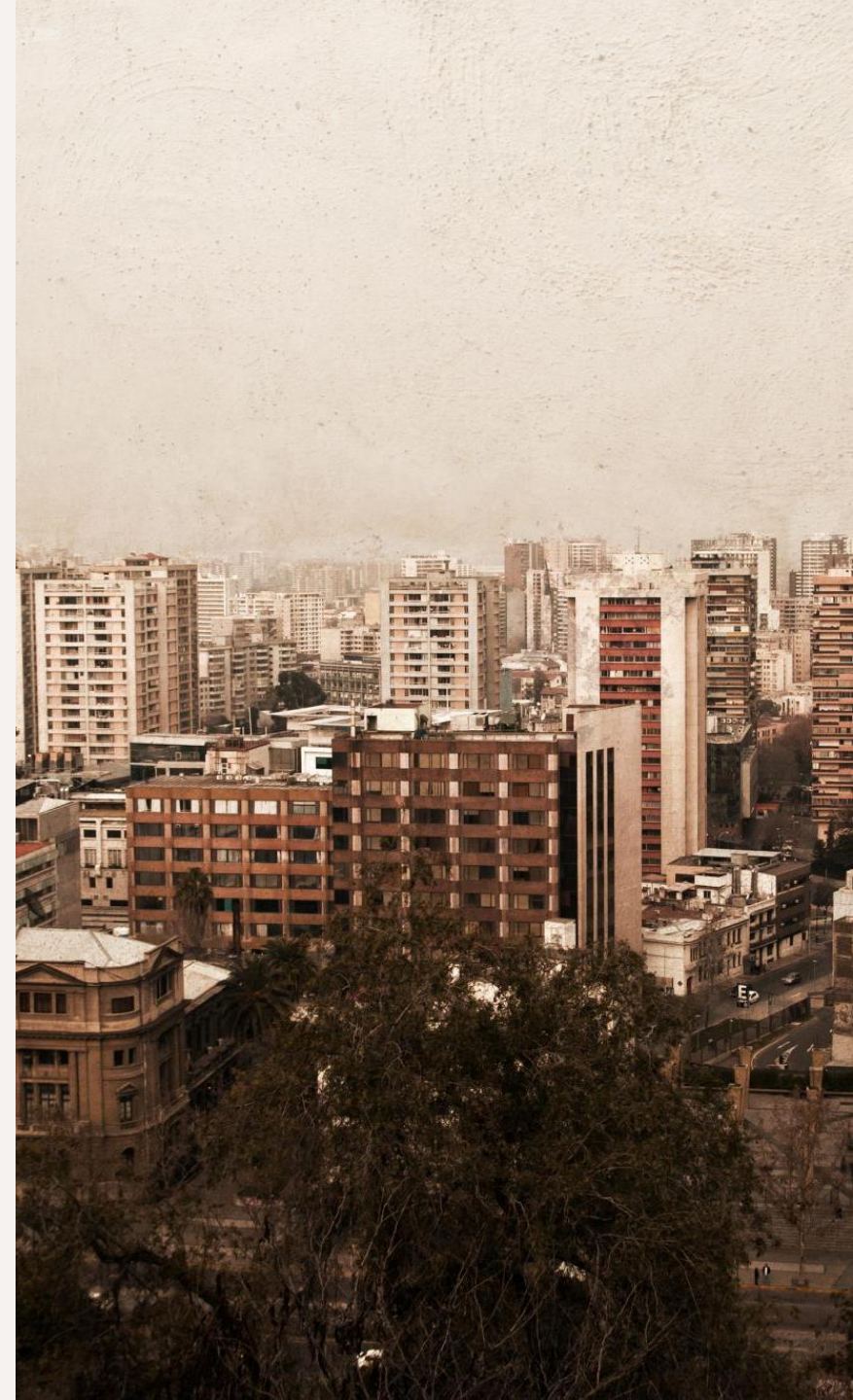
India's Intervention

India's intervention was a key milestone impacting the outcome of the Bangladesh Liberation War.

Long-term Consequences

The conflict reshaped South Asian geopolitics, national identities, and regional power dynamics.

Slide 3



Background: The Two Wings of Pakistan

Geographical Separation

The two wings of Pakistan were separated by over 1,600 kilometers of Indian territory, causing major governance challenges.

Cultural and Linguistic Differences

West Pakistan was mainly Punjabi and Urdu-speaking, while East Pakistan was Bengali-speaking, highlighting deep cultural divides.

Political and National Identity Conflict

Linguistic and cultural differences fueled early political conflicts over national identity and representation between the two wings.



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Economic and Political Tensions

Economic & Political Disparities

Economic Contribution vs Funding

East Pakistan generated much national revenue, especially from jute exports, but received little development funding.

Political Dominance

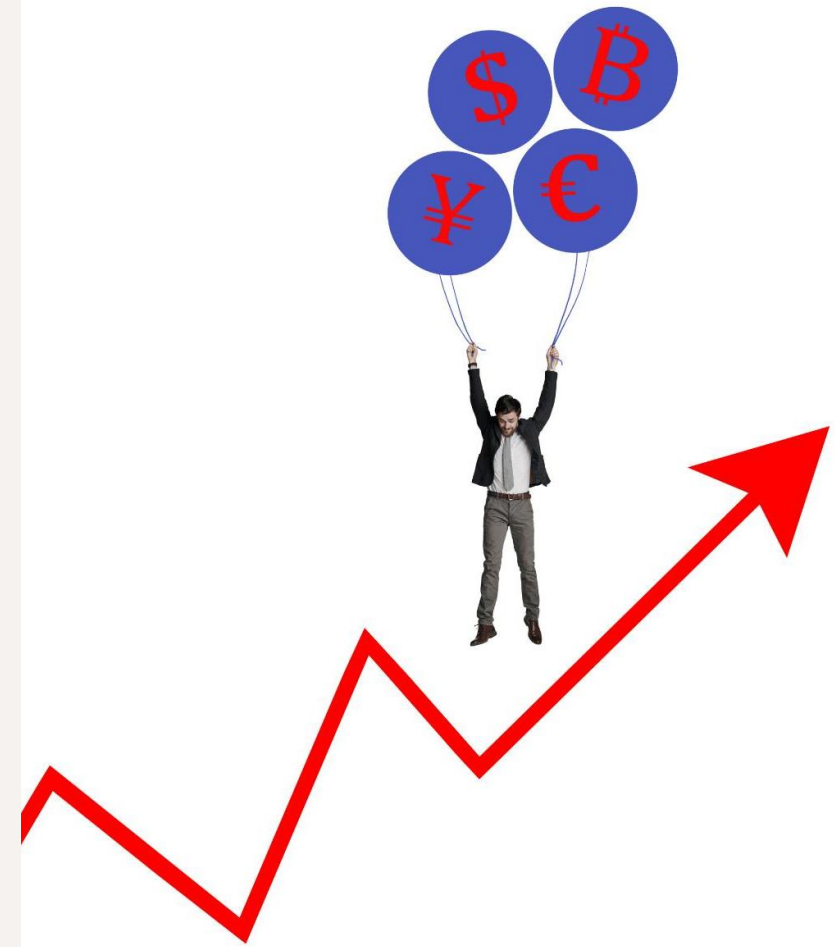
West Pakistan controlled key military, bureaucratic, and government positions, marginalizing Bengali representation.

Neglect of Development

Eastern wing faced ongoing neglect in infrastructure and industrial development, contributing to poverty and alienation.

Root Causes of Grievances

Economic exploitation and political exclusion combined to fuel nationalist movements and autonomy demands.



Rise of Bengali Nationalism

Language Movement of 1952

The declaration of Urdu as sole national language sparked protests making Bengali a symbol of cultural resistance.

Student Martyrs' Impact

The deaths of protesting students galvanized public support and transformed language into a defiant cultural emblem.

Rise of Awami League

The Awami League became the political voice articulating grievances and leading the push for autonomy.

From Protest to Autonomy

Cultural resistance evolved into structured political demands, building mass support for independence over time.

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Leadership and Political Programs

Sheikh Mujibur Rahman: Champion of Bengali Rights

Charismatic Leadership

Sheikh Mujibur Rahman was known for his powerful oratory that deeply inspired the Bengali masses.

Champion of Autonomy

He advocated for autonomy, equitable resource distribution, and ending political marginalization of Bengalis.

Leadership Impact

His leadership provided direction and legitimacy to the struggle for Bangladesh's independence.

1970 Election Significance

His decisive electoral victory was pivotal, and refusal to transfer power led to a national crisis.

Slide 7



The Six Points (1966)

- Federal Parliamentary System: A true federation with a parliamentary form of government
- Fiscal Autonomy: Provinces to have full control over taxation and revenue collection
- Limited Central Power: Central government limited to defense and foreign affairs only
- Foreign Exchange: Separate accounts for foreign exchange earning for each wing
- Separate Currencies: Two sperate but freely convertible currencies for each wing
- Paramilitary Force: Authority for provinces to raise their own paramilitary forces.



Roots of the Six-Point Movement

Economic Exploitation

Resources from East Pakistan were diverted to develop West Pakistan, causing severe economic disparity.

Political Marginalization

East Pakistanis, though majority, had minimal influence in central government decision-making.

Cultural Suppression

Efforts to impose Urdu and suppress Bengali culture heightened the desire to preserve identity.

Quest for Autonomy

Collective factors led to a strong demand for self-rule to protect economic and cultural interests.

Slide 9



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Escalation Toward Conflict

The Agartala Conspiracy Case (1968)

- **Background and Charges:** In 1968, the government of Pakistan filed a case against Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and 34 others, accusing them of conspiring with India to achieve the secession of East Pakistan through an armed revolt.
- **Political Impact:** The trial backfired, turning Sheikh Mujib into a symbol of resistance and further galvanizing Bengali nationalism.
- **Outcome:** Massive public protests and the 1969 uprising forced the government to withdraw all charges and release all detainees unconditionally.
- **Significance:** The case's failure was a major political victory for the Awami League, setting the stage for their landslide victory in the 1970 elections.

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AGREEMENT FOR SALE

P.S.- East Agartala
Mouja- Indranagar
Total land- 0.040 Acar.
Valued at Rs. 15,50,000/- only
Advance Rs. 6,00,000/- only.
Period- 3 month 15 days

AGREEMENT FOR SALE

THIS AGREEMENT FOR SALE is made at Agartala 27th day of Dec 2024 A.D

:-B E T W E E N :-

SRI BIJOY SAHA, S/O. Sri Shibulal Saha, resident of Vill- Jagaharimura P.S. East Agartala, P.O Agartala College, Dist- West Tripura, by faith - Hindu, by Profession- Govt. Service, Pin -799004, Citizen of India. here-in-after called as the first party "**VENDEE/ PURCHASER**".

... OF THE ONE PARTY(1ST).

A N D

SRI BARUN KANTI DAS, S/O. Late Abani Mohan Das, at present Kshudiram Basu Lane, Dhaleswar, P.S. East Agartala, P.O -Dhaleswar, Dist - West Tripura, by faith - Hindu, by Profession- Business, Pin-799007, Citizen of India, here-in-after called the as the second party "**VENDOR/ SELLER**".

... OF THE OTHER PARTY(2ND).

WHEREAS the 2nd Party being absolute owner and possessor landed premises within District- West Tripura, Sub-Divn & Sub- Registry - Sadar, P.S.- East Agartala, Tahasil & Mouja - Indranagar, Revenue Circle - East Agartala, bearing **Khatian No. 14826**, Sabek Dag No. PB-8504-4522, 4520, **R.S. Plot No. 8869, 8874/25428**, land measuring 0.135 acres Nal classes land by way of Partition Deed Bearing No 2023/SDR/I/17753, Book No - I, Volume No - 79, Page No - 157 to 160 Year 2023. Dated 14/07/2023, and have been possessing without any interruption and disturbance from any corner and got mutation in her favour and also record of right has been created in her name in the concerning revenue authority.

AND WHEREAS the 2nd Party for his personal need of cash money he intends to sell **0.040 Acar** Nal classes land

Legal Framework Order (LFO) – 1970

Purpose of LFO 1970

The Legal Framework Order set conditions for Pakistan's first general elections to form a National Assembly for drafting a new constitution.

Constraints Imposed

LFO required the constitution to preserve Islamic ideology and maintain territorial integrity within a federal system.

Presidential Authority

President held power to approve or reject the constitution, limiting democratic authority and centralizing control.

Impact on Democracy

These conditions undermined democratic transition and contributed to future political conflict in Pakistan.



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Democratic Breakdown and War

1970 General Elections: A Decisive Mandate



Election Outcome and Regional Divide

The 1970 elections revealed a stark political divide between East and West Pakistan, reflecting regional tensions.

Awami League's Majority Win

Awami League secured an absolute majority in the National Assembly, entitled to form the government.

Democratic Breach and Crisis

Refusal to transfer power breached democratic norms, triggering a constitutional crisis and unrest.

Missed Peaceful Resolution

The election was a missed opportunity for peaceful conflict resolution, escalating tensions further.

The Genesis of the Crisis



Ignored Democratic Mandate

The ruling elite of West Pakistan disregarded the democratic election results, causing political unrest.

Postponement of Assembly Session

The delay of the National Assembly session on March 1, 1971, sparked widespread outrage in East Pakistan.

Escalation to Confrontation

The deadlock led to increased mistrust and shifted the crisis beyond political negotiation to confrontation.

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Military Confrontation and Independence

Bhutto's Role & Failed Negotiations



Bhutto's Political Stance

Bhutto refused to attend the National Assembly, emphasizing political division with the phrase 'Idhar hum, udhar tum.'

Failed Negotiations

Multiple meetings among political leaders failed due to eroded trust, ending hopes for compromise.

Turning Point in Crisis

The breakdown of talks marked a critical turning point, closing the door on political solutions.

Operation Searchlight

Political Breakdown: Following the failure of negotiations between Yahya Khan, Zulfikar Ali Bhutto, and Sheikh Mujib, the military opted for a "force-only" solution.

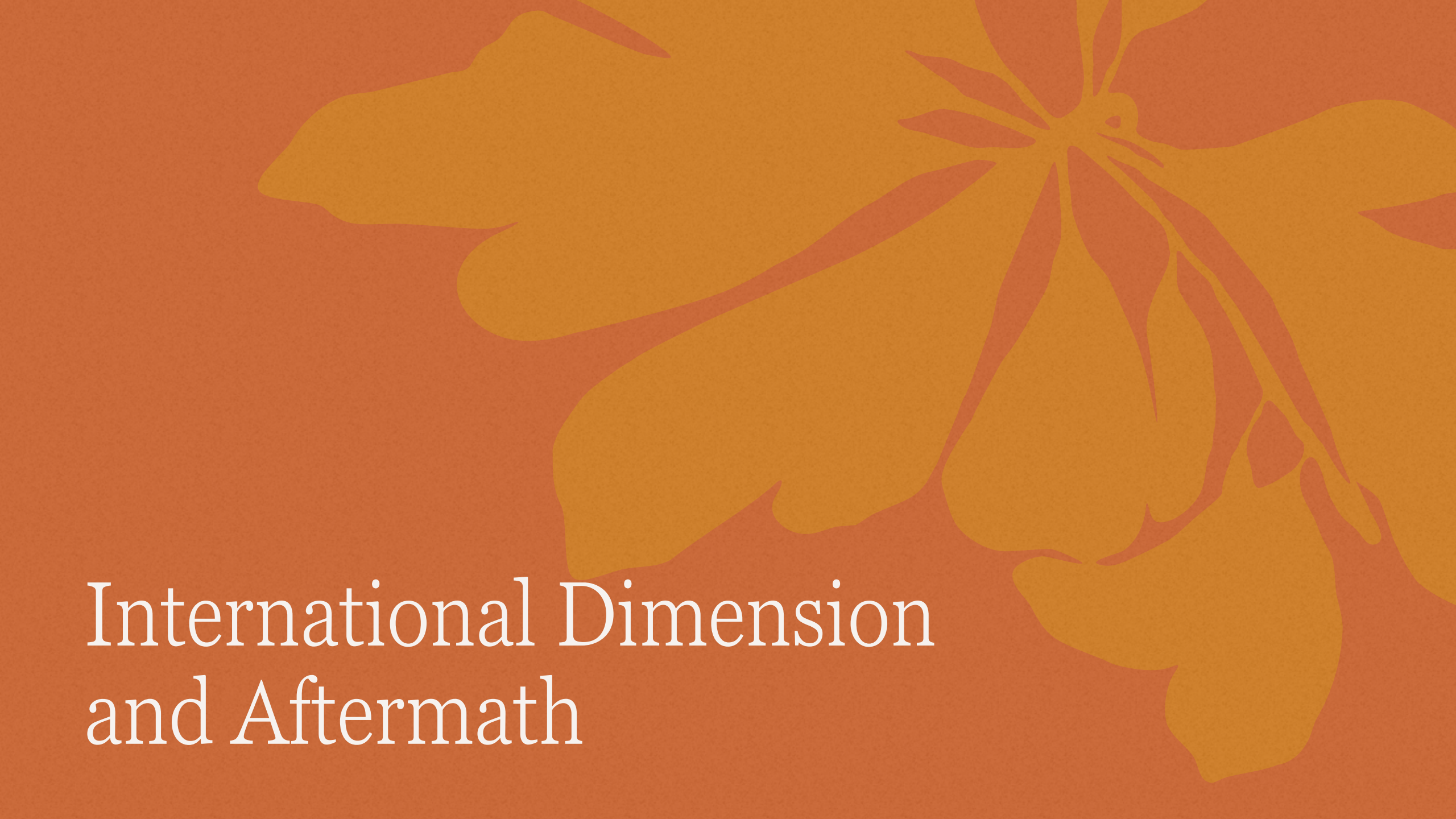
The Strategy: A pre-emptive military strike aimed at crushing the Bengali nationalist movement by arresting leadership and disarming Bengali police and soldiers.

University Massacre: Dhaka University became a primary target; students and faculty members were systematically killed to eliminate the intellectual leadership of the movement.

Humanitarian Crisis: The brutality of the night led to the formal declaration of Bangladesh's independence (March 26) and the start of a massive refugee exodus (10 million people) to India.

The Transformation: What began as a political struggle for autonomy transformed into an all-out War of Liberation.



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International Dimension and Aftermath



India's Pivotal Role & Resistance

Support to Mukti Bahini

India strategically provided training and arms to the Mukti Bahini, empowering resistance forces in the conflict.

Refugee Hosting

India hosted nearly ten million refugees, showcasing humanitarian efforts during the regional conflict.

Military Intervention

On December 3, 1971, India's military intervention decisively shifted the conflict's balance in favor of the allied forces.

The Fall of Dhaka and Aftermath

Surrender and Conflict End

The Pakistan Army Eastern Command surrendered on December 16, 1971, ending the conflict and leading to Bangladesh's birth.

Prisoners of War

About 93,000 soldiers were taken as prisoners of war following the surrender in 1971.

Simla Agreement 1972

The Simla Agreement established ceasefire terms and facilitated POW repatriation between involved nations.

Lessons from Conflict

Key lessons highlight political justice, equitable growth, diplomacy, and inclusivity as vital for lasting peace.

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Thank You

Expressing Gratitude

This slide formally thanks the audience for their attention and participation during the presentation.

Invitation to Reflect

It encourages the audience to reflect on the historical lessons shared throughout the presentation.

